

Thinking In Every Direction

The diagram's real job is to protect you from your own first instinct.

The Wrong Bone

A company shipping wrong items blamed the careless pickers for months. More training, then warnings, then incentives, and the error rate barely moved. They grabbed the most obvious bone, manpower, and never let go long enough to look anywhere else.

Hidden Causes

A proper fishbone session forced the other categories open. Machine revealed old scanners misreading barcodes. Method exposed near identical products stored side by side. Measurement showed the error system caught only half of all errors. The real causes were hiding where nobody wanted to look.

Add Five Whys

Marry the fishbone to the Five Whys. When you land on a candidate cause, ask why about five times until you hit something fundamental. Scanners misread, because they are five years old, because no one owns the replacement budget. Fishbone makes you think wide, Five Whys makes you think deep.

Remember this

Together they help a white belt find a root cause instead of a scapegoat.